

Scale, Engage, or Both?: Potential and Perils of Applying Large Language Models in Interview and Conversation-Based Research

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Abstract

An increasing number of studies apply tools powered by large language models (LLMs) to interview and conversation-based research, one of the most commonly used research methods in CSCW. This panel invites the CSCW community to critically debate the role of LLMs in reshaping interview-based methods. We aim to explore how these tools might (1) address persistent challenges in conversation-based research, such as limited scalability and participant engagement, (2) introduce novel methodological possibilities, and (3) surface additional practical, technical, and ethical concerns. The panel discussion will be grounded on the panelists' prior experience applying LLMs to their own interview and conversation-based research. We ask whether LLMs offer unique advantages to enhance interview research, beyond automating certain aspects of the research process. Through this discussion, we encourage researchers to reflect on how applying LLM tools may require rethinking research design, conversational protocols, and ethical practices.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → HCI design and evaluation methods.

Keywords

large language models as research tools, conversation-based research, interview

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1 Motivation & Overview of the Panel

Rich, engaging conversations have been essential to CSCW's methodological toolkit. Interviews, workshops, participatory sessions, and other conversation-based methods have enabled researchers to engage deeply with participants and uncover nuanced insights for designing sociotechnical systems. Over time, these methods have adapted to changing communication infrastructures – from in-person encounters to phone interviews, and to video-mediated platforms like Zoom. Each shift has prompted renewed scrutiny: How does the medium shape the message? What new dynamics emerge in interaction with participants?

Most recently, uses of large-language-model-powered tools have become increasingly common in research workflows [7, 8]. While large language models (LLMs) have already gained traction in surveys and experiments, their widespread use has raised significant concerns among researchers [12]. In contrast, LLMs have yet to be widely adopted in interviews and other **conversation-based research methods**. This moment offers the CSCW community a timely opportunity to critically reflect on the challenges and possibilities of augmenting conversation-based research with AI – before LLM use becomes as prevalent in conversational contexts as it has in survey-based and experimental ones.

We refer to “conversation-based research” as research methods that center conversations as a core means of inquiry and data collection, such as interviews, conversation probes, and dialogue-based experimental stimuli. We deliberately adopt this scope to encourage methodological discussion beyond any single tactic. In fact, one goal of the panel is to explore how applying LLMs as research tools might transform conventional methodological boundaries (e.g., qualitative, quantitative, or mixed methods).

This panel challenges the growing pressure to adopt LLMs in research simply because “everyone is using them.” As these tools

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become more accessible, there is a risk that their methodological and epistemological implications are overlooked [6]. We invite the CSCW community to think carefully and collectively about the implications of adopting LLMs in conversation-based research and industry practices, such as UX research and hiring processes. Our goal is not to endorse or reject these tools, but to examine them through CSCW's enduring values: care, rigor, and reflexivity.

Relevance to CSCW: This panel addresses a timely and important topic for the CSCW community for two key reasons: First, conversation-based methods have long underpinned CSCW's suite of research methods, enabling deep, situated understandings of sociotechnical systems. A review of CSCW papers from 1990–2015 shows nearly half rely primarily on interviews [13], rising to 60–70% in the past five years. As these methods continue to drive much of CSCW's insight, it is critical to examine how they may evolve with the rise of LLMs. Second, while numerous panels and workshops at CSCW and related venues have explored the use of LLMs as research tools – including some led by this panel's organizers [1, 5] – a recurring challenge has been the breadth of these conversations. Prior discussions often span a wide range of methods and applications, making it difficult to engage deeply with the nuances of any single approach. Hence, our panel takes a more focused approach to foster a more in-depth dialogue.

2 Themes and Questions for Panel Discussion

To ensure our panel engages the most relevant and pressing concerns of the CSCW community, we will circulate a short survey through social media, our professional networks, and Slack/Discord channels from previous CSCW events, to gather reflections from researchers and practitioners on interview-based methods and the potential integration of LLMs in the research pipeline. Responses will inform and refine the panel's agenda. Based on prior research and our own experience organizing LLM-focused workshops and panels, we propose four initial themes for discussion. Themes 1 and 2 will focus on specific, practical details for carrying out conversation-based research and designing LLM tools for such processes. Theme 3 will engage in higher-level methodological discussions. Finally, we close the conversation by raising ethical concerns (Theme 4).

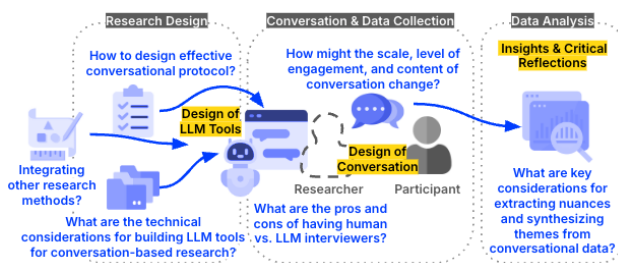


Figure 1: Recent work has applied LLM tools to various aspects of interview and conversation-based research. This panel invites CSCW researchers to critically reflect on the design of LLM tools and conversation protocols, as well as the downstream effects they have on conversational content and insights.

Theme 1: Can LLMs support both scaling and deepening engagement of interview research? Interview and conversation-based methods offer depth but often face criticism for limited scale due to resource constraints. This theme explores whether LLMs can help researchers scale up interview efforts while still enabling context-rich conversations.

- Do LLMs introduce new ways of engaging participants, or do they replicate existing methods at scale?
- What additional benefits might LLMs bring beyond scaling, such as dynamic responsiveness, access to embedded knowledge, or personalization?

Theme 2: Designing for conversation: Structured prompts vs. organic flow. Using LLMs in interview research requires researchers to make explicit design choices about how conversations are initiated, shaped, and interpreted. This theme addresses the technical and methodological considerations in building and deploying LLM-based agents to conduct interviews. Discussion will focus on:

- How should we design protocols that balance standardization with flexibility for LLM-mediated conversations?
- What technical affordances (e.g., prompting, RAG, scripted transitions) support contextually responsive dialogue?

Theme 3: Can LLMs help reconfigure methodological boundaries in CSCW? LLMs offer the potential to blur traditional boundaries between different methodological approaches. This theme invites discussion on whether LLM-mediated interviews could lead to new hybrid methods; for instance, transforming survey instruments into conversational protocols or generating structured data from unstructured dialogue [14]. We will also ask:

- What new methodological spaces might emerge from the integration of LLMs?
- Can LLMs act as more than tools, functioning instead as research collaborators for study design?

Theme 4: What are the ethical tensions and research opportunities in LLM-mediated conversation-based research? LLMs may open new possibilities for addressing persistent issues in interview research, such as power imbalances, disclosure discomfort, and interviewer effects, but they also introduce ethical and epistemological concerns:

- Where might we find the greatest opportunities for applying LLMs in conversation-based research, e.g., having participants talk about sensitive topics that they would otherwise feel uncomfortable sharing with researchers?
- Can LLMs reduce perceived judgment or social pressure in sensitive conversations, or do they risk further dehumanizing data collection?
- How do issues of privacy, bias, consent, and trust shift when conversations are mediated by AI?

3 Panel Format and Participation Plan

This panel will take the form of a structured roundtable discussion (Introduction of panelists and their work: 10 mins; Discussion of each theme: 15 mins x 4; Q&A with the audience: 20 mins). One of the organizers will serve as a moderator, guiding the conversation among panelists, managing time and transitions across discussion

themes, and integrating questions from the audience. We will assign informal roles to panelists, encouraging each to represent either a supportive or an opposing voice regarding the use of LLMs in conversation-based research. This approach ensures that the panel does not converge prematurely on consensus, but instead surfaces meaningful tensions and multiple viewpoints.

Interaction with the Audience. We will use Slido (www.slido.com) to collect real-time questions, comments, and upvotes during the panel. Rather than saving audience input for the end, the moderator will integrate selected questions throughout the panel to enrich discussions. We will dedicate a Q&A at the end of the panel to allow direct engagement, giving attendees space to challenge ideas, raise concerns, or share insights.

Accessibility of the Panel. We will work with the on-site tech support team to ensure availability of live captioning for both in-person and remote attendees. Slido will be used as a low-barrier platform for real-time participation, including for those who may prefer text-based engagement over spoken discussion.

Post-Panel Engagement. To extend the conversation beyond the session, we will host an informal social gathering (e.g., coffee meetup) for panelists and on-site attendees. We will also launch a dedicated Slack channel to support ongoing conversations, resource sharing, and future collaborations. Finally, the organizers will produce a white paper synthesizing the panel's key insights.

4 Expected Outcomes

1. **Identify which limitations of interview methods might be uniquely addressed by LLMs (Themes 1 & 3).** Rather than adopting LLMs indiscriminately, we aim to surface cases where their capabilities – such as scalability, multilingual support, or responsiveness – uniquely offer solutions that existing tools do not. The panel discussion will reflect not only on what LLMs can do, but on *whether and why* we truly need them in research.
2. **Explore how LLMs should be designed and applied in conversation-based research workflows (Theme 2).** We will pinpoint specific technical challenges and methodological considerations for designing LLM-powered research tools. We aim to identify best practices, potential pitfalls, and new research opportunities.
3. **Surface technical, methodological, and ethical considerations through real-world use cases (Theme 4).** We will learn from researchers who have already experimented with LLMs in conversation-based research. We will assemble concerns and open questions from the broader CSCW community to jointly reflect on this new methodological frontier.

5 Panel Organizers and Speakers

Angel Hsing-Chi Hwang (Organizer & Moderator) is an Assistant Professor at the Annenberg School for Communication at University of Southern California. Most of her work involves designing and applying conversational agents as study probes in experimental sessions. She recently organized a panel at CHI'25 to discuss the use of LLM tools for human subjects research [5], where she identified the need to continue the discussions with a more focused scope.

Marianne Aubin Le Quéré (Organizer) is a postdoctoral fellow at the Princeton Center for Information Technology Policy. Her work focuses on how AI and emerging technologies impact news and civic information ecosystems. Marianne's recent work at CHI and CSCW includes investigations and workshops [1] around how researchers can use LLMs for both qualitative and quantitative data analysis [11].

Hope Schroeder (Organizer) is a Ph.D. student at the MIT Center for Constructive Communication/MIT Media Lab. Her work examines and develops methods of using LLMs in computational social science and interfaces for making sense of conversation data. Her recent work studies the use of LLMs in annotations [10], and reports on use of RAG systems in data exploration. Some work in meta-science includes a study of positionality statements at FAccT, and a full paper at CHI on LLMs in qualitative research, with Marianne Aubin Le Quéré [11].

Alejandro Cuevas (Speaker) is a postdoctoral fellow at Princeton's Center for Information Technology Policy (CITP). He focuses on the shady, suspicious, and illicit corners of the Internet—and how emerging technologies like generative AI both influence and are influenced by these spaces. He blends gonzo and computational social science: first-person fieldwork in underground communities paired with large-scale measurements. His recent work applied LLM chatbots to collect large-scale qualitative data [3].

Steven Dow (Speaker) is a Professor in the Cognitive Science Department and the Design Lab at UC San Diego, and Director of the ProtoLab research group. His research on human-computer interaction, creativity, social computing and collective intelligence seeks to engage diverse teams and communities to co-create better, more inclusive, and more sustainable outcomes. His recent research examines the use of LLMs in study sessions that require attention to conversational cues [9] and prompt reflection during ideation processes [16].

Shivani Kapania (Speaker) is a Ph.D. student at the Human-Computer Interaction Institute at Carnegie Mellon University. Her research focuses on creating mechanisms for accountability and greater worker agency in interactions with machine learning systems configured as part of transnational AI supply chains. Her recent work explored the risks and downstream impacts of synthetic research data [6].

Eugenia Rho (Speaker) is an Assistant Professor of Computer Science at Virginia Tech, where she leads the Society + AI & Language (SAIL) Lab. Her research focuses on building and evaluating AI language technologies that mediate human communication, with particular attention to how LLMs interpret, intervene in, and shape dialogue. Her work examines how AI systems can model conversational dynamics, anticipate communication breakdowns, and support users in high-stakes, cognitively diverse, or socially sensitive contexts [2, 4, 15].

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